

Einstein on the web

The full collection of Albert Einstein's writings will be put on the web, as part of massive project to digitise his work



Renew your TV each year

Samsung introduces Smart Evolution kits with its 2012 range of Smart TVs; this will allow addition of hardware

Blu-ray Player Test



Philips BDP3200/94

grated Wi-Fi, a second USB port is provided for a Wi-Fi adapter. Incidentally, there's no component video output, just composite and HDMI. It's well built, but looks very understated, and won't raise any eyebrows, switched on or off.

Though the Sony BDP-S380 doesn't look very different, it's extremely classy when in action. The centre of the fascia has a similar combination of Blu-ray drive and display as the BDP3200. Below this is an angled ledge that hosts the hardware keys. Between these two elements you find the USB port sitting snugly. When switched on, there's a slightly arced pale blue

(some might argue it's white) LED in the middle of the fascia, lending it a very elegant look. All AV ports along with the LAN port are on the back. The metal finish of the rest of the body looks good and the built quality is high.

Panasonic's DMP-BD75 is the third Blu-ray player in the ₹10,000 price bracket but is slightly more expensive than the Philips and Sony ones we tested. One of the reasons being that the DMP-BD75 is the most compact of the three. On the front is a single piece design that runs top down and side-to-side. The glossy finish throughout is a dust magnet though. On the left

is the disc drive, and somewhere in the middle is the USB port. To the right of that is the play/pause and stop buttons. However, the power and eject key are on the edge of the top panel. The power key lies near the optical drive and the one on the opposite edge is the drive eject key – a strange and confusing design. Interchanging the two buttons in the final design would have made it slightly less confusing to use. Where this Blu-ray player from

The next player is the Philips BDP5200, which smoothly takes us into the category priced above ₹10,000. Keep this beside the BDP3200, and most people won't be able to differentiate between the two. The Blu-ray logo on the left of the drive on the BDP3200 gives way to the Blu-ray 3D logo. Else, it looks exactly the same. They're both built impressively.

LG's BD670, in the midst of all the understated looks and gentle advertisements of its



Sony BDP-S380

Panasonic sacrifices is with certain ports – there's no component video out, no optical or coaxial audio or even a USB port for a Wi-Fi adapter.

features, silently screams to be noticed. The Blu-ray drive begins at the left edge, slightly rounded here, and moves closer to the centre of the front panel.

HOW WE TESTED

For the comparison test of Blu-ray players, as for all other products that we test, we follow the same testing pattern as a standalone review, all year long.

Preparing the product

We have noticed that Blu-ray players get firmware updates quite regularly. Before testing, we connect these to the network and update them with the latest version available. In most cases, these updates bring in performance improvements or even new features. To test these devices without considering the latest features offered would be wrong.

Feature listing

We take a look at all the features of the Blu-ray player – playback capabilities, full range of AV and web connectivity options, online services, audio and video containers supported, sources for external media and even some services that may be unique to individual players. It is important to

rate players based on the features, considering the variety we have seen within this bunch.

Design and usability

We do realize that looks and design of a product is open to individual preferences, but we try to keep it as scientific as possible when scoring the ergonomics of a product. We consider factors like build quality, materials used, placement of keys, placement of ports, quality of remote etc., and score it according to a preset scoring pattern.

Performance

Unlike laptops or smartphones, we don't have exhaustive list of tests for Blu-ray players. Which is what makes analyzing the performance very critical. To start off, we keep a

standard test-bed for all players – same television, AV receiver and speaker set. We even ensure that we use the same HDMI cable and the same power source across all products. Content sources remain the same as well – Blu-ray discs, DVDs and the same external USB drive are used to test all the players. We even use the same video files throughout, which include a variety of video formats to test the compatibility of a player. We look at the

quality of video at the 1080p resolution from all inputs. We also give points for the startup time taken by the player, and lower is better. For every input source, we log the time taken for the playback to start. From the table with this test, you will see how varied the times are across all devices, with lower being better. We also ran the HDV Blu-ray benchmark on all devices, to give simple scores for performance.

